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1. Halfords' Current B2C Digital Services and Critical Evaluation

Halfords Group plc is a major UK provider of motoring and cycling products and services. Its business-to-consumer (B2C) network comprises 370 retail stores, 496 consumer garages and approximately 250 mobile service vans, supported by online retail and service booking channels (Halfords Group plc, 2026). Customers may therefore move between several digital and physical touchpoints within the same journey, from researching a service online to visiting a garage and receiving follow up information. The quality of the overall experience depends not only on each interaction, but also on how effectively information is transferred between them.

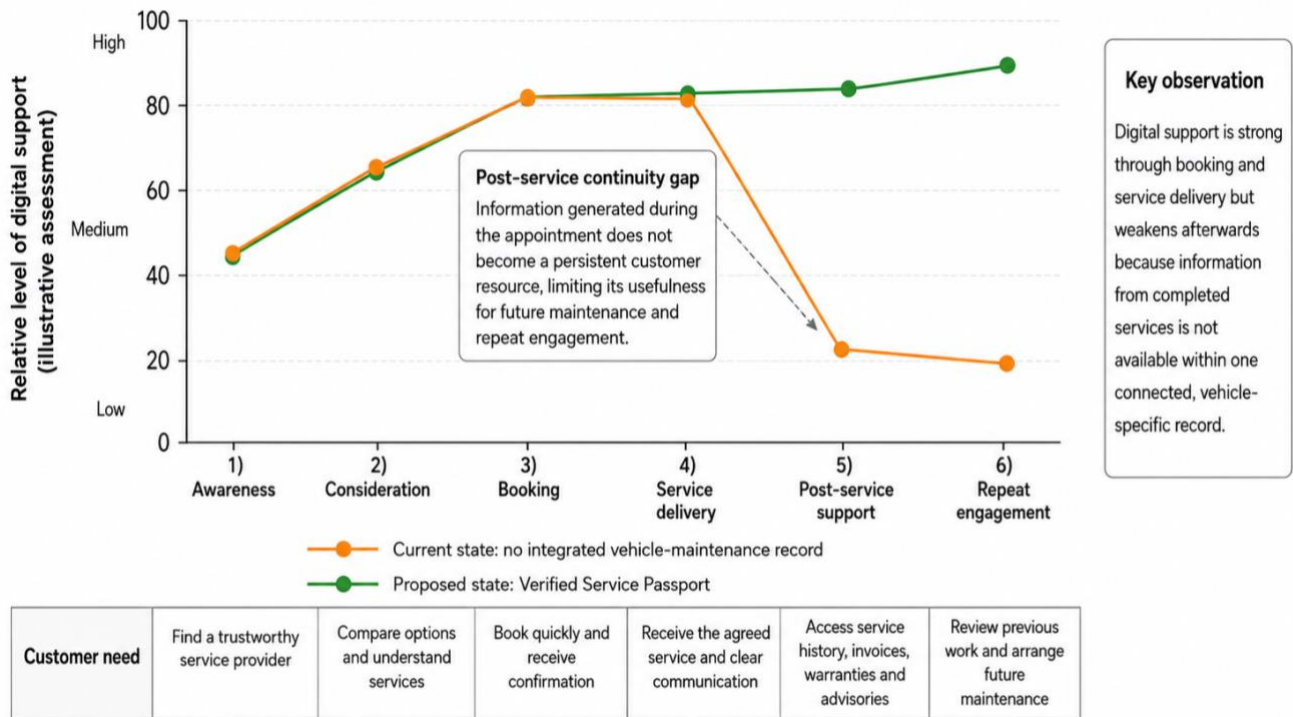
Halfords provides a convenient digital route for customers arranging motoring services. Users can enter vehicle details, identify suitable options, select a location and appointment, and book an MOT (annual roadworthiness test), service or repair online. Registered customers can also access previous orders and bookings through their accounts, reducing the effort involved in finding and managing services. Halfords strengthened this experience during FY2026 through platform improvements that increased website speed by up to 50%, reduced friction across the online journey and increased the proportion of searches leading to a relevant customer action by approximately 50%. Expanded use of live chat also allowed enquiries to be resolved more efficiently and at a lower operating cost (Halfords Group plc, 2026).

However, automotive servicing produces information whose value continues after the vehicle has been collected. Each inspection, repair or routine service may generate findings concerning vehicle condition, completed work, mileage, replaced parts, fluids, warranties and future advisories. Customers may later require this information when planning maintenance, questioning previous work, making a warranty claim or selling the vehicle. Halfords' digital service must therefore be evaluated not only by the convenience of booking, but also by the quality of access to information after service completion.

At present, this information remains fragmented. Halfords' Bookings & Orders function displays transactions completed through a logged-in account, but it is not presented as a complete maintenance history linked to the vehicle (Halfords, no date a). Halfords' servicing information also indicates that customers cannot yet view their complete Halfords service history within one consolidated online record, although the organisation intends to introduce this capability (Halfords, no date b). Inspection findings, invoices, warranties and recommendations may consequently remain divided across separate bookings, emails and service documents. The limitation is therefore not a lack of digital access, but the absence of a persistent vehicle record that remains useful across successive visits.

This gap is significant because customer experience develops across connected pre-purchase, purchase and post-purchase interactions (Lemon and Verhoef, 2016). Patrício et al. (2011)

similarly argue that individual service encounters should be integrated within a wider service system. Figure 1 applies this perspective to Halfords. It shows that digital support remains relatively strong through awareness, booking and service delivery, but weakens afterwards when information from the completed appointment does not become a continuing customer resource. The figure therefore identifies a specific post-service continuity gap, rather than a general weakness across the entire customer journey.



Note: Levels are an indicative author assessment of visible digital support and are not measured customer-experience scores.

Figure 1- Halfords' current B2C customer journey and post service continuity gap

Competitor practice provides a useful benchmark for addressing this limitation. Kwik Fit's Vehicle Health Check presents inspection findings and photographs within a customer facing report, improving visibility during an individual visit (Kwik Fit, 2026). Halfords could develop a more distinctive proposition by connecting comparable information across successive services and repairs. Its opportunity is not simply to reproduce a point in time report, but to provide continuity across the vehicle's maintenance lifecycle.

Overall, Halfords offers effective digital access to service discovery, booking and delivery. Its principal weakness emerges afterwards, when useful information remains attached to separate transactions rather than becoming part of a continuing vehicle record. This unmet need provides the basis for the Halfords Verified Service Passport proposed in Section 2

2. Proposed Digital Service: Halfords Verified Service Passport

To address the post-service continuity gap identified in Section 1, Halfords should introduce a Verified Service Passport within its existing customer account. Linked to the vehicle registration, the Passport would combine information from successive garage visits into one continuing maintenance history rather than displaying each booking as a separate transaction.

After every MOT, service or repair completed at a participating Halfords garage, a structured entry would record the date, location, mileage, inspection findings, work completed, parts or fluids used, advisories, invoices and relevant warranties. Photographs or diagnostic results could be included where they provide useful evidence. An authorised employee would approve the entry before it became visible to the customer. In this context, “verified” means that Halfords can identify who approved the record and trace any later amendments; it does not imply independent certification.

The resulting timeline would allow customers to review previous work, retrieve supporting documents, monitor outstanding recommendations and share a limited summary for warranty or resale purposes. The first release should focus on cars serviced through Halfords consumer garages, with bicycle records and external partnerships considered only after the core process has proved reliable.

2.1. Primary observation evidence

The need for the Passport is supported by two forms of primary observation.

The first was a structured walkthrough of Halfords’ website and online account. As shown in Figure 2, the current system already connects the customer, vehicle and transaction through the MOT booking page, My Vehicles and Bookings & Orders. However, the observed account did not provide one clearly identifiable record combining previous inspections, completed work, invoices, warranties and outstanding advisories. This does not establish that Halfords stores no internal service data but shows that such information was not presented as an integrated customer facing maintenance history.

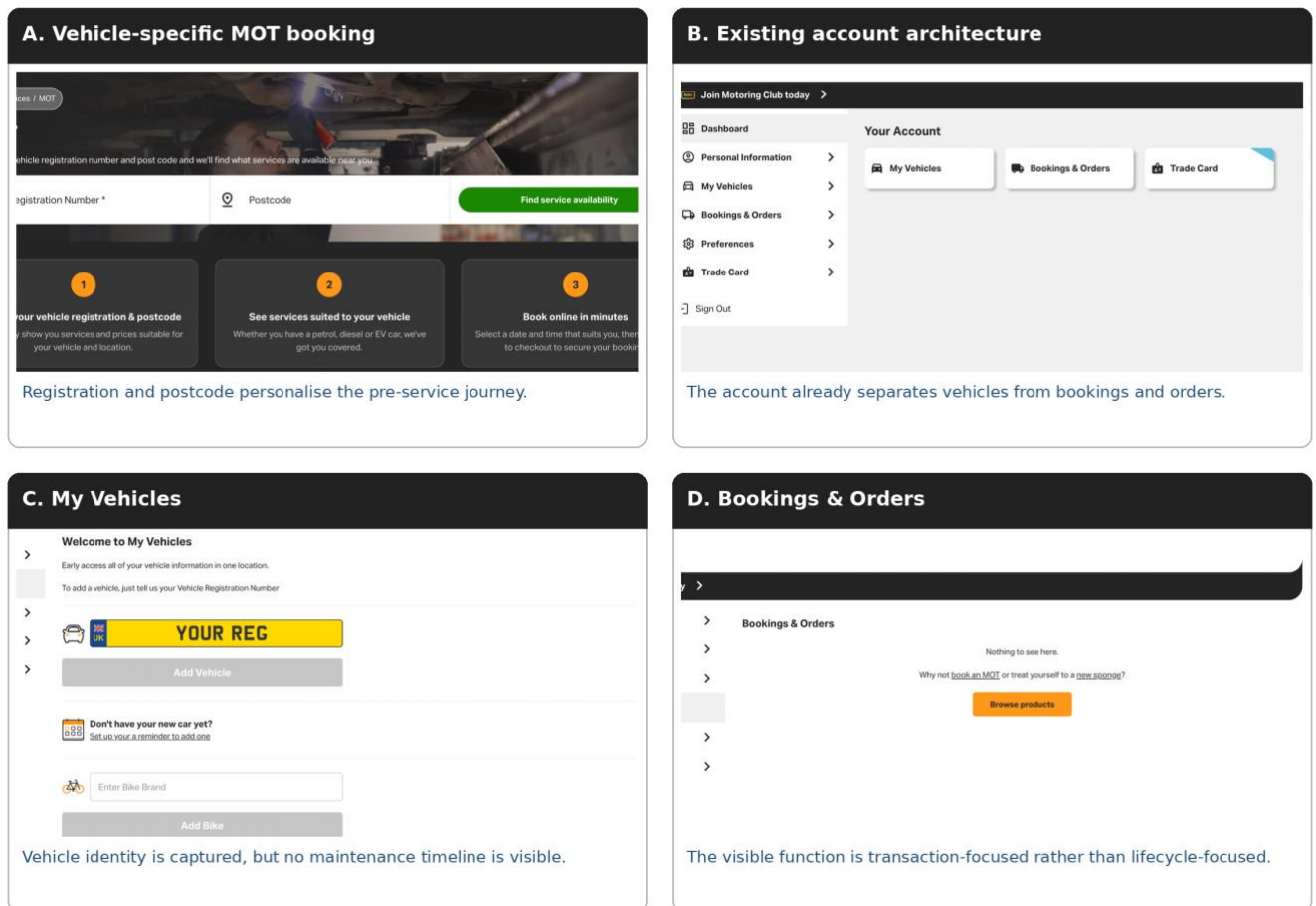
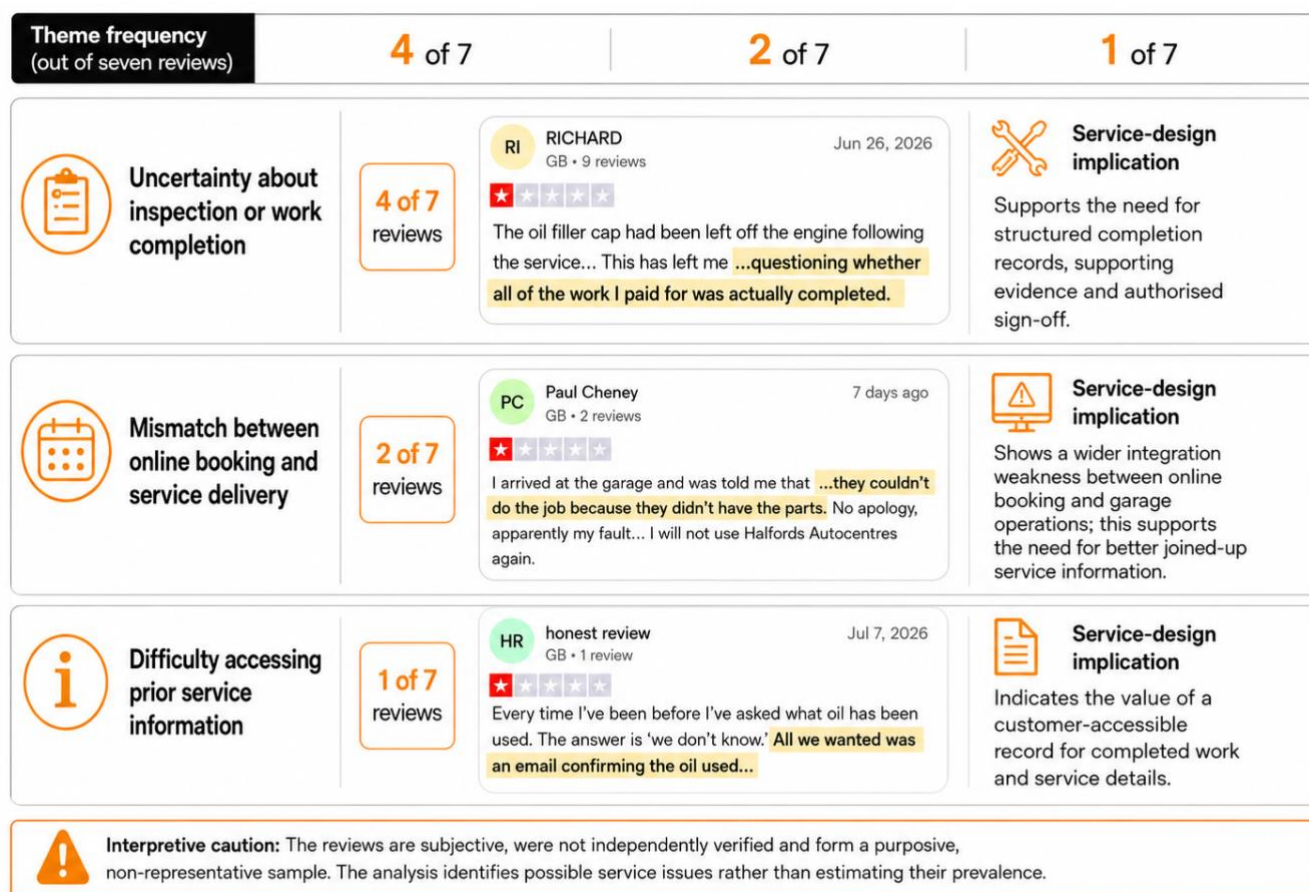


Figure 2- Interface analysis of Halfords' current digital customer journey

The second observation analysed seven recent one star Halfords Autocentres reviews published between 20 May and 14 July 2026 (Trustpilot, 2026). The reviews were selected because they concerned servicing, service delivery or access to previous service information. Four questioned whether inspections or paid work had been completed correctly, two described appointments being accepted even though the required parts or equipment were unavailable, and one reported difficulty obtaining information about the oil used during an earlier service. The second theme does not indicate that the online booking interface is ineffective; rather, it suggests a possible disconnect between customer-facing booking information and garage operations. Figure 3 summarises these themes, while selected original review screenshots are included in Appendix A.



Source: Author's analysis of seven Trustpilot reviews published between 20 May and 14 July 2026.

Figure 3- Thematic analysis of selected recent Halfords Autocentres reviews

The reviews are subjective, unverified and not representative of all Halfords customers. Nevertheless, they identify situations in which customers struggled to establish what had been arranged, completed or recorded. Considered together, the observations suggest that Halfords provides a convenient booking journey, but information continuity between booking, service delivery and post-service support is less consistent. The Passport primarily addresses the post-service problem by creating a structured and accessible vehicle record.

2.2. Customer value and organizational value capture

For customers, the Passport would reduce the effort required to reconstruct a vehicle's history and improve transparency when planning maintenance, raising a complaint, making a warranty enquiry or selling the vehicle.

Halfords could capture value through repeat servicing, greater conversion of clearly justified maintenance recommendations, improved Motoring Club retention and lower complaint handling costs. In FY2026, 420,000 Premium Motoring Club members generated approximately £22 million in subscription revenue, equivalent to around £52 per member (Halfords Group plc, 2026). Illustratively, a one percentage point improvement in retention would preserve approximately 4,200

memberships and £0.22 million in annual revenue. This is not a forecast and excludes additional servicing income and possible cost savings. The Passport should therefore be included with participating services rather than sold as a separate subscription.

2.3. Redesigned service process

Figure 4 maps the draft idea of the proposed process across customer, frontstage, backstage and system activities. When a service is booked, the relevant vehicle record is retrieved or created. The technician records the inspection findings, completed work and supporting evidence; incomplete entries are returned for correction, while approved entries are added to the Passport and released to the customer. The process map demonstrates that the proposal is not simply another account page. It changes how service information is captured, checked, stored and reused across future customer interactions.

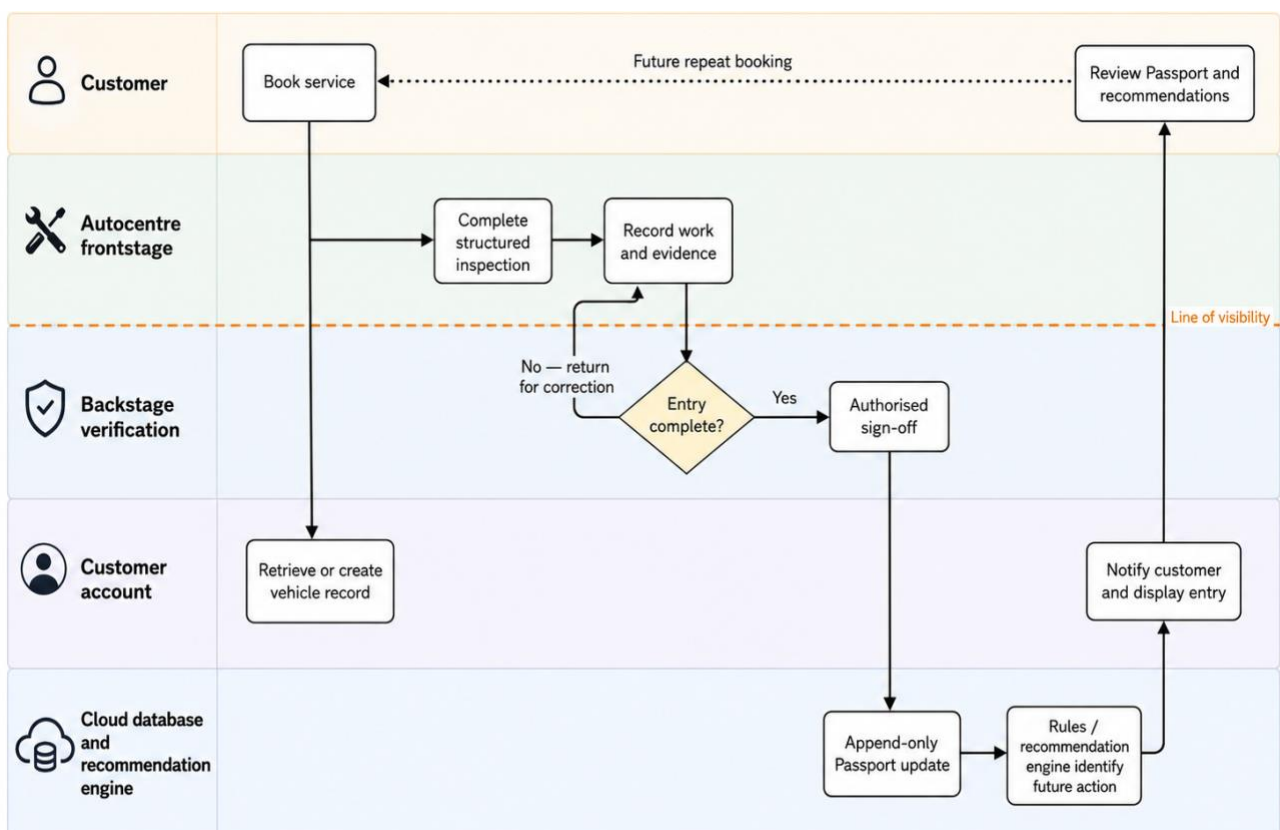


Figure 4- To be business process for the Halfords Verified Service Passport

3. Technology Selection and Justification

The Verified Service Passport requires two technological capabilities. First, Halfords needs a secure system that can maintain one vehicle record across its garage network. Second, it needs a

method of using the accumulated information to provide relevant maintenance guidance. The technologies should therefore be selected according to the tasks required by the service rather than their novelty.

This follows Task Technology Fit theory, which proposes that technology improves performance when its capabilities match the activities it must support (Goodhue and Thompson, 1995). For the Passport, the principal functional requirements are creating, retrieving and updating vehicle records across locations, integrating them with the existing customer account and supporting future personalisation. The system must also meet non functional requirements relating to security, data integrity, scalability, regulatory compliance, cost and employee usability.

Table 1 applies Multi Criteria Decision Analysis (MCDA) to three possible record architectures. MCDA compares alternatives against weighted criteria, making the basis of the decision more transparent (Government Analysis Function, 2024). Data integrity, cross location access and governance receive the greatest weight because the Passport would provide limited value if its records were unreliable or inaccessible. The scores are the author's informed assessment rather than measured technical performance.

Table 1- MCDA of service record technologies

Selection criterion	Weight	Cloud database with audit logging	Permissioned blockchain	Separate local databases
Data integrity and auditability	25%	5	5	3
Access across locations	20%	5	4	2
Security and governance control	20%	4	3	3
Cost and implementation feasibility	15%	5	2	4
Scalability and AI compatibility	10%	5	3	2
Future external interoperability	10%	4	5	2
Weighted score / 5	100%	4.70	3.75	2.75

Note: 1 = weak fit; 5 = strong fit. Weights and scores are assessment. Scores indicate relative fit for the initial Halfords launch rather than absolute technological performance.

The results identify a centralised cloud database with append only audit logging as the strongest option for launch. This would allow authorised Halfords garages to access the same vehicle history while recording who created or amended each entry. Changes would be added to the audit history rather than replacing the original record. Security controls, backups and integration with the customer account could also be managed consistently. Separate local databases would be unsuitable because they would preserve the fragmentation that the Passport is intended to remove.

A permissioned blockchain offers strong tamper evidence and may become useful if insurers, leasing companies, resale platforms or independent garages later need to verify or contribute records. However, it is unnecessary at launch because Halfords would remain the trusted administrator and principal creator of the data. Blockchain is most appropriate when several organisations must update a shared record without relying on one central authority (Wüst and Gervais, 2018). Introducing it initially would therefore increase cost and governance complexity without meeting an otherwise unsatisfied requirement. It should instead be considered as a future interoperability layer.

The second capability concerns maintenance guidance. Artificial intelligence would not replace technicians; its purpose would be to use previous vehicle information to make recommendations more relevant. Table 2 compares rule based reminders, supervised machine learning and unsupervised anomaly detection.

Table 2- Task technology fit of maintenance guidance alternatives

Alternative	Strength	Limitation	Proposed role
Rule based reminders	Transparent and immediately implementable	Fixed time or mileage thresholds	Launch baseline
Supervised machine learning	Learns from known maintenance outcomes	Needs labelled, reliable data	Selected AI capability after validation
Unsupervised anomaly detection	Identifies unusual patterns	Does not predict a defined customer outcome	Possible internal quality control tool

Rule based reminders should provide the launch baseline because they are transparent and can apply established manufacturer time and mileage intervals. Once the Passport contains sufficient validated records, supervised machine learning could estimate defined outcomes, such as whether a component is likely to require attention within a specified period. Relevant inputs could include vehicle age, mileage, previous advisories and repair history.

Supervised learning is a stronger fit than unsupervised learning because the customer facing task has a defined prediction target. Unsupervised anomaly detection could later support internal quality control by identifying unusual inspection or record entry patterns, but it would not directly predict a specific maintenance need. Research on automotive predictive maintenance also identifies reliable labelled data and understandable model outputs as essential conditions for successful implementation (Theissler et al., 2021).

The recommended architecture is therefore phased. The cloud database would establish the core Passport, rule based guidance would support launch, and supervised machine learning would be introduced only after data quality had been demonstrated. Recommendations should remain advisory, explain their main basis and permit technician review.

4. Implementation Lifecycle

Implementation should follow the technology intensive initiative lifecycle adapted from Markus and Tanis (2000): initiation, acquisition, development and implementation, shakedown, onward and upward, and possible termination. This framework structures the overall project. Within it, Scrum would guide software development, MoSCoW would control the scope of the first release, and gradual rollout would determine how the service is introduced across the garage network.

During initiation, Halfords should confirm the business case, define the first release scope and assign responsibility for delivery. The initial service should cover cars at a selected group of consumer garages and exclude external data sharing, blockchain and automated safety decisions. Governance should involve representatives from Autocentres operations, customer experience, IT, information security, data protection and frontline teams. Success measures should include complete Passport entries, customer activation, repeat bookings, employee completion time and complaints concerning missing or disputed service information.

During acquisition, Halfords would decide which capabilities should be developed internally and which should be obtained from suppliers. This would include cloud hosting, database and audit log services, interface development, integration and security testing. Data ownership, access rights and retention periods should also be defined, supported by a data protection impact assessment. Only historical records that can be matched reliably to the correct vehicle should be migrated.

Development and implementation should use Scrum based short cycles, user stories and a prioritised backlog (Schwaber and Sutherland, 2020). Incremental development would add capabilities in manageable stages, such as record creation, document retrieval and customer access. Iterative development would refine those capabilities through repeated testing and feedback. MoSCoW prioritisation should prevent the first release from becoming unnecessarily complex. As shown in Table 3, the minimum viable service must include a vehicle linked timeline,

structured records, employee sign-off, an audit history and customer access. AI guidance and diagnostic attachments should not delay the core launch.

Table 3- MoSCoW prioritization of Passport functionality

Must have	Should have	Could have	Will not have initially
Vehicle linked service timeline	Rule based maintenance reminders	Downloadable resale summary	Public or permissioned blockchain
Structured inspection and work record	Photographic / diagnostic attachments	Controlled insurer or DVSA connection	External organisations adding records
Employee sign off and audit trail	Technician quality dashboard	Bicycle service Passport	Marketplace or social sharing
Customer dashboard and document retrieval	Outstanding action reminders	Parts-inventory integration	Fully automated safety decisions
Role based access and account recovery		Validated AI maintenance guidance	

Note: DVSA = Driver and Vehicle Standards Agency.

The shakedown stage should begin with a pilot across a small number of operationally varied garages. Halfords should monitor incomplete entries, duplicate records, integration failures, employee workload and customer understanding. Local champions, practical support and regular feedback would allow the process to be revised before expansion. Any AI model should initially operate in shadow mode, meaning its outputs are compared with service rules and technician judgement without being shown to customers.

A gradual rollout is more suitable than either a Big Bang launch or full parallel operation. A Big Bang approach would expose the entire network to unresolved failures, while parallel operation could require employees to maintain two complete record processes. Gradual regional expansion would take longer, but it would contain risk and allow each deployment wave to benefit from earlier learning. Expansion should continue only when the previous group meets agreed security, data quality and usability thresholds.

An indicative twelve month programme could allocate two months to initiation and acquisition, four months to development and testing, two months to pilot shakedown and four months to controlled expansion. These timings are planning assumptions and should be revised after technical discovery.

During onward and upward, Halfords should continue improving the service after launch. This Permanent Beta approach could support later additions such as validated AI guidance, resale summaries and controlled external verification. If the pilot repeatedly failed to meet security, adoption or data quality standards, the termination stage would allow the initiative to be redesigned or stopped before further investment.

5. Risk Analysis and Mitigation

The Verified Service Passport introduces operational and technological risks alongside its expected customer and commercial benefits. Table 4 assesses four material risks according to likelihood and impact, following Kerzner's (2006) risk management approach. Cybersecurity and inaccurate record creation receive the highest priority because both could directly undermine the reliability and trust on which the service depends.

Table 4- Risk assessment for the Verified Service Passport

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Exposure
Cyberattack, unauthorized access or personal data breach	Medium	High	Serious
Incomplete or inaccurate employee record entry	Medium	High	Serious
Inaccurate AI maintenance recommendation	Medium	Medium	Moderate
Integration failure or temporary service unavailability	Medium	Medium	Moderate

The first priority is cybersecurity and data protection. The Passport would consolidate vehicle registrations, service histories, invoices, customer account details and potentially inspection images. Although this would improve access, it would also increase the consequences of unauthorised access or system compromise. A breach could create regulatory and recovery costs while damaging customer confidence.

Mitigation should begin with data protection and security by design. Halfords should retain only necessary personal information, encrypt data in transit and at rest, and apply role based access with multi factor authentication. Access and amendment logs should make unusual activity traceable. Supplier due diligence, penetration testing and access reviews should be completed before each rollout stage, supported by tested backups and an incident response procedure. These controls align with ICO data protection by design guidance and NCSC cloud security principles (ICO, 2026; NCSC, 2022).

The second priority is incomplete or inaccurate employee record entry. The primary observations in Section 2 showed that customers may already experience uncertainty about what was inspected,

completed or recorded. The Passport would not resolve this problem if employees omitted information, used generic entries or completed records retrospectively. Describing an inaccurate record as “verified” could intensify rather than reduce mistrust.

Mitigation should therefore combine workflow controls with employee support. Structured fields and validation should prevent incomplete entries from being released, while authorised sign off would create accountability. Frontline employees should participate in pilot design so that the process remains practical. Training, local champions and feedback should support adoption, while dashboards and sample audits should monitor completion, correction and exception rates. Performance measures should reward record accuracy rather than speed alone.

The remaining risks have lower assessed exposure but still require control. AI recommendations should remain in shadow mode until their accuracy and interpretability are demonstrated and should always permit human review. Integration failures should be managed through pilot deployment, monitoring, backups and rollback procedures. The Passport is therefore feasible, provided that security and record quality are built into the service from the outset.

6. Conclusion

Halfords currently provides effective digital access to motoring services, but the customer journey becomes less connected after service completion. The Verified Service Passport would address this gap by turning information generated during garage visits into a continuing vehicle record. A cloud based system, phased introduction of maintenance guidance and gradual rollout provide a realistic foundation for implementation. With strong controls for cybersecurity and record accuracy, the service could improve transparency, repeat engagement and customer retention while reducing the cost of disputes.

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8. Appendices

Appendix A. Primary Observation Evidence: Selected Halfords Autocentres Reviews:

The screenshots below provide the original public review evidence used for the three illustrative examples in Figure 3. The reviews are subjective and were not independently verified.

A1. Uncertainty about inspection or work completion

76%

8%

3%

3%

10%

RI

RICHARD

GB • 9 reviews

★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Avoid Halfords Autocentre for servicing & MOT

Avoid Halfords for servicing – my experience has completely destroyed my confidence in them.

I booked my Mercedes in for a Major Service and MOT in May 2026 at 65,926 miles. Since then, I've barely driven the car and it has only covered 296 miles, with the mileage now at 66,222.

After finishing work one day, I noticed fresh oil on my driveway and underneath the car. When I opened the bonnet, I discovered something that completely shocked me.

The oil filler cap had been left off the engine following the service. It had been left loose in the engine bay, resting on top of the radiator/fan area, while oil had been sprayed around the engine bay and underneath the vehicle. Had I gone on a long journey, this could easily have resulted in serious engine damage.

To make matters worse, when I checked the oil, it was already extremely black despite the car having travelled only 296 miles since a Major Service, where a full oil and filter change is supposed to be carried out. This has left me questioning whether all of the work I paid for was actually completed.

I contacted the store and was called by the manager. Instead of apologising, I was told this wasn't his mechanic's fault and that it must have been an engine issue that blew the oil filler cap off.

I explained that this simply doesn't make sense. There is very little clearance between the engine and the bonnet, and the oil filler cap sits lower than the engine cover. If it had somehow blown off while driving, it could not have landed neatly on top of the radiator/fan assembly inside the engine bay. The much more obvious explanation is that it was never

Jun 26, 2026

Source: Trustpilot review screenshot captured by the author on 15 July 2026.

A2. Disconnect between booking information and garage readiness

76%

8%

3%

3%

10%



Paul Cheney

GB • 2 reviews

7 days ago



DO NOT BOOK ONLINE

DO NOT BOOK ONLINE. As I've just done. I took the day off to get my brakes fixed and booked online, 1 week before the appointment. When I arrived at the garage I was told me that they couldn't do the job because they didn't have the parts. No apology, apparently my fault. I was informed that when you book online, stock is not checked and parts aren't ordered. There is no mention of this on the Halfords website. The garage couldn't even process a refund, I spent 30 minutes on the phone, with customer services, to get my money back. I will not use Halfords Autocentres again.

8 likes

Unrated review

Source: Trustpilot review screenshot captured by the author on 15 July 2026.

A3. Difficulty accessing prior service information



honest review

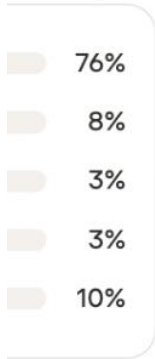
GB • 1 review

Jul 7, 2026



Halfords Johnstone - avoid

Took my car in which had just passed its MOT for 4 new tyres. Was informed that the garage had sheared a wheel bolt trying to remove wheel but "they can't fix this" so I was sent away with a sheared nut to go find a garage myself! Seriously, they made no suggestion of keeping the car in their garage so they could fix it, instead I was sent away with a dangerous defect. What sort of garage specialises in wheels and tyres but won't sort out a broken nut which they broke in the first place? They were very keen for me to return to them to have the 4th tyre fitted. No wonder. The other three wheels had been overtorqued and the wheels way overinflated over safe pressure. I took the fourth tyre and the car to another local garage who did a great job for me.



clive churchward

GB • 103 reviews

Jun 3, 2026



On line chat line gets disconnected & given wrong information

We need confirmation of the oil used in a service. On the chat they said they need the Reg and date. We gave them that and they said they need the booking number. We did have this so we send them the Halford receipt. They said that was no good. We then had to call the local Halford who were very helpful and gave us the booking number. On chat they now said that the job was not booked in my name (it was booked under our company name). All we wanted was an email confirming the oil used and after four hours online I still do not have the email that we need. Disconnect three times and given incorrect information several times. Very poor service. CASE 00807484

Source: Trustpilot review screenshot